LEARNER ATTACHMENT

Four Cybersecurity Threat Categories

Tier 1 recognition guide - classify the observed pattern without making a severity or breach determination

USE Select the best-supported category, cite at least two observable signals, and record when a multi-stage incident crosses categories.

Category	Observable signals	Tier 1 action boundary
1. Phishing / social engineering	Impersonated sender; urgent request; credential or MFA prompt; deceptive link or attachment	Preserve message identifiers and report through the approved phishing/security channel
2. Credential compromise / account takeover	Credentials entered on an untrusted page; unfamiliar risky sign-in; unexpected MFA prompt; suspicious session	Invoke only approved containment; route investigation and remediation to SOC/IAM
3. Malware / ransomware	Security alert; malicious attachment or process; file encryption; endpoint isolation event	Do not interact with the suspected payload; follow endpoint isolation and SOC procedures
4. Unauthorized access / data exposure	Unexpected permissions, anonymous link, external sharing event, anomalous file access, access by an unapproved identity	Preserve permissions and audit evidence; route governance and privacy questions

Multi-stage classification

A single case can move across categories. For example, an impersonated support message is phishing; entering credentials creates suspected credential exposure; an unfamiliar sign-in suggests credential misuse; and a file-access event creates a possible data-exposure question. Report the chain without asserting who controlled the session or whether PHI was compromised.

Evidence standard

- Use ticket facts, message identifiers, Defender incident or alert IDs, Entra sign-in records, and Purview audit events.
- Separate reported facts from tool observations and from unresolved questions.
- Do not convert a risk detection into proof of compromise; Microsoft Entra risk signals require investigation.
- Do not convert possible ePHI involvement into a HIPAA breach conclusion.

Authoritative sources

- HHS OCR - October 2024 Cybersecurity Newsletter: Social Engineering
- HHS - Summary of the HIPAA Security Rule
- Microsoft - Phishing investigation playbook
- Microsoft Entra - Investigate identity risk